

VeteranNet / NextStep Executive

Comprehensive Business Plan & Technical Requirements Specification

Document Type: Product Specification & Strategy

Target Audience: Mid-to-Senior Professionals (12+ Yrs Exp)

Date: August 2026

Executive Summary: A self-hosted, privacy-first peer networking and fractional advisory platform built to solve systemic age-related displacement (ATS auto-rejections, redundancy, and corporate restructuring) for professionals with 12+ years of experience.

1. Recommended Tech Stack (100% Free & Open-Source)

To meet your requirement of a **free, open-source, and self-hosted** stack capable of complex relational data (users, fractional projects, peer endorsements, feeds, and referrals), we recommend an integrated low-code microservice architecture:

Primary Framework: NocoBase (or Baserow) + PostgreSQL

- **Core Platform — NocoBase (Self-Hosted via Docker):** Unlike basic form-builders, NocoBase is a extensible open-source no-code/low-code web application platform. It natively supports granular Role-Based Access Control (RBAC), multi-table relations, visual page layout creation, and flexible workflow automation.
- **Database — PostgreSQL:** Enterprise-grade open-source relational database storing encrypted user profiles, project listings, and peer referral graphs.
- **Self-Hosted Auth & Identity — Authentik / Keycloak:** Provides secure passwordless login, OIDC/OAuth2, and strict verification workflows without vendor lock-in.
- **Deployment Target:** Local Docker Compose / On-Premises Server or low-cost Linux VPS (\$5–\$10/mo).

Component	Tool Recommendation	License	Role in Architecture
Backend & UI Builder	NocoBase / Baserow	Apache 2.0 / MIT	Visual database schema, custom UI pages, and admin engine.
Database Engine	PostgreSQL 16	PostgreSQL License	Relational storage for profiles, skills, and engagement data.
Search Engine	Meilisearch	MIT	Fast, age-blind talent search and vector/keyword matching.
Container Host	Docker Compose	Apache 2.0	One-click local self-hosting and zero-downtime maintenance.

2. Business Plan Strategy

2.1 Market Positioning & Legal Compliance

To avoid app-store policy violations and public accommodation civil rights issues regarding age-gating, the platform uses an **Experience-Based Threshold** instead of biological age:

- **Qualification Rule:** Gate entry to individuals with **12+ years of verified professional experience** or senior/ executive titles (Lead, Staff, Manager, Director, Architect, VP).
- **Positioning:** "The Executive Advisory & Peer Referral Network for Senior Domain Experts."

2.2 Monetization Architecture

Revenue Stream	Model	Target Rate / Pricing
Peer Network Access	Freemium / Premium Tier	Free core feed; \$29/mo for direct referral routing & advisory tools.
Fractional Marketplace	Take-Fee / Commission	10% fee on fractional C-suite/Architect consulting contracts.
Enterprise Outplacement	B2B SaaS License	Corporate licenses purchased by companies undergoing downsizing.

3. Product Requirements Document (PRD)

3.1 Functional Requirements Matrix

Module ID	Feature Name	Description & Business Logic	Priority
FR-01	Age-Blind Talent Card	Profiles showcase verified domain achievements, skills, and project history. Graduation years, birthdates, and photo requirements are completely omitted to neutralize ATS bias.	High
FR-02	Peer Referral Bridge	Gated introduction engine allowing senior members to directly refer peers into active openings at their current/former firms, bypassing cold ATS applications.	High
FR-03	Fractional & Advisory Engine	Marketplace listing short-term interim roles, advisory board posts, and part-time domain consultant requests from startups and SMBs.	Medium
FR-04	Domain-to-AI Upskilling Hub	Curated repository and discussion threads focused on leveraging modern generative AI tools to amplify 15+ years of domain expertise.	Medium

3.2 Technical & Security Architecture Requirements

- **Data Isolation & Self-Hosting:** All data stored in locally hosted Docker volumes with automated encrypted pg_dump backups.
- **Granular Role-Based Access Control (RBAC):**
 - *Unverified Applicant:* Access restricted to onboarding form and identity upload.

- *Verified Veteran Member*: Full access to search talent, post articles, send referral requests, and bid on fractional work.
- *Corporate Client / Recruiter*: Access restricted to viewing anonymous capability cards and posting fractional roles.
- **Compliance**: Fully compliant with GDPR and local data protection standards by enabling complete profile deletion and zero tracking telemetry.

4. Implementation & Deployment Roadmap

1. **Phase 1: Environment Setup (Week 1)** — Spin up Docker environment running NocoBase + PostgreSQL + Authentik on local infrastructure.
2. **Phase 2: Schema & RBAC Design (Weeks 2–3)** — Configure collections for Profiles, Experience Logs, Referral Requests, and Fractional Opportunities.
3. **Phase 3: Page Creation & Workflows (Weeks 4–5)** — Build visual views (Talent Directory, Opportunity Board, Peer Discussion Feed).
4. **Phase 4: Testing & Pilot Launch (Week 6)** — Onboard an initial cohort of 50 senior professionals for peer verification testing.